14. India as Teacher by Negative Example

A Brief Recap

India and China enjoyed more than 1,000 years of uninterrupted trade and cultural exchanges during the first millennium CE . As described in the preceding chapters, this enduring engagement flowed across the Central Asian bridgehead, through the Tibetan plateau and the maritime links connecting peninsular India with the eastern seaboard of China. The spread of Buddhism in China became the prism through which China perceived India. India was the 'Western Paradise', the birthplace of the Buddha and a centre of advanced knowledge and philosophy. This perception, however, challenged the notion of Chinese centrality, and was for this reason rejected at times by Chinese intellectuals as an alien influence, even though Buddhism was embraced as a comforting faith by the populace.

These interconnections between India and China were often interrupted by political turmoil and transitions in both countries as well as in the intermediary realms. However, during the second millennium CE , these interruptions became more extended and relations more distant. Engagement continued, though at a lower pitch and often through their peripheries.

But even during the sixteenth century, since India was still esteemed in China as a civilized and sacred land, Jesuit missionaries such as Matteo Ricci passed themselves off as monks visiting from India, or Tianzhu Guo (the western treasure country). They even dressed in Buddhist robes.

To recap briefly what has been covered in Chapters 9 and 10, during the medieval era, the port of Calicut maintained a flourishing maritime trade with China and served as a pivot point for the seven voyages undertaken by the Ming dynasty admiral Zheng He, who died in Calicut in 1433 at the end of the last voyage. There are interesting descriptions of the ports of Calicut and Cambay in the chronicles of Ma Huan, who accompanied Zheng He on the voyages. The chronicles are entitled 'The Triumphant Visions of the